

NAMED FOR THE MYTHS

Mythology is all around us. Lots of things in the natural world are named after gods and creatures from ancient Greek myths. Many share characteristics with whomever or whatever they are named after.

PLANETS

Most of the planets in our solar system are named after ancient Greek gods. They have been given the Latin versions, used by the ancient Romans, of their original Greek names. The Romans admired the ancient Greeks and shared many of their gods.



Mercury (Hermes) is the fastest planet in the solar system. It is named after the messenger god.



Venus (Aphrodite) is named after the goddess of love. It is the brightest planet in the sky.



Mars (Ares), also known as "the red planet" because of its red color, is named for the god of war.

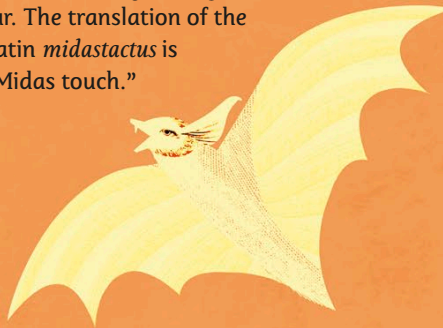


Earth (Gaia) is the only planet not named for a god, although the goddess Gaia is often known as Mother Earth.

The harpy eagle has the scientific name *Harpia harpyja*. It is named after the mythological harpy, which had the body of a bird and the face of a woman.



The golden myotis bat has the scientific name *Myotis midastactus*. It gets its name from King Midas because of its golden-yellow fur. The translation of the Latin *midastactus* is "Midas touch."



ANIMALS

Lots of animals have names that come from Greek mythology because people thought their behavior or appearance was similar to characters from myth.

Crocus was a mortal who fell in love with a nymph named Smilax. She didn't return his love, however, and the gods transformed the heartbroken Crocus into a crocus flower.



Hyacinths are named for a mortal friend of the god Apollo, Hyacinthus, whom Apollo accidentally killed. Where Hyacinthus fell, the flower bloomed.

